



Figure 5: KRunner

KRunner

This is the 'Run' command that you activate by pressing **Alt+F2** from the keyboard. Although it's been available for a year now, things have been more aesthetically refined in this release. You can make it work in either of two modes—command-based like we've been used to since ages, or now even task-based. By default, you can key in the commands to launch an application—as soon as you start typing, it starts filtering from the names of the applications available. For example, take a look at Figure 5—as soon as I type 'Kon', it filters from all the commands for apps that contain the letters 'kon'. I can now either key in a few more letters to fine-tune the filtering further, or use **Tab** to select the program I need to launch.

You can also use KRunner for a lot of other purposes, viz., as a calculator, to find documents, search by tags, or even visit website URLs you directly key in. This extended functionality is courtesy several plugins that power its back-end. A few examples are spell checking, browser history, recent documents, etc. You can check out the full listing of plugins by accessing its configuration dialogue. In fact, this is where you can switch from command-based to task-based mode by activating it from the 'User Interface' tab. As you can see in Figure 6, now you can find applications by their task, rather than command—for example, I typed 'write' and it shows me all the applications that can help me write something. However, since I'm too used to the command-based mode, I

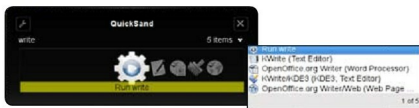


Figure 6: QuickSand—KRunner in task mode

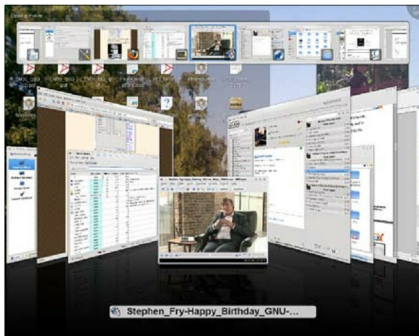


Figure 7: The Alt + Tab effect

found the task-oriented method kind of difficult to use.

Talking about the command mode, thanks to the back-end calculator plug-in, I can now see the outcome of simple math problems from KRunner itself, without launching the calculator application separately. For example, type '2134*134=', excluding the single quotes. Did you see '285554' right away? Pretty cool, eh?

Overall, KRunner is not just a regular Run dialog any more—it's turning out to be a pretty powerful application in itself.

Kwin

Kwin is basically the window manager—something that acts as a container for the apps we run on our desktop. Even in KDE 4.1, we saw some pretty cool compositing and desktop effects features added

to Kwin. This release has added even more plug-ins for effects, and the ones that were already available, have been fine tuned—refer to Figure 7 for an improved Alt+Tab effect, when too many windows are open; note the horizontal viewer at the top. You can activate it from the 'Desktop' settings in the Personal Settings app (the replacement for KControl from the KDE3 branch).

I won't go on and on about the desktop effects it offers; you should try it out yourself to experience its niceties. Maybe you'll find a lot less polish with respect to some features that Compiz Fusion also offers, but things aren't that bad either. In fact, looking at the features made available during the last six months, I won't be surprised if it catches up with Compiz by the time KDE 4.3 comes out.

As for me, although I usually keep